

Click, Comply, Governed: The Case of the European Citizens' Initiative

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Intro

Officially launched on May 9th 2012 for Europe Day, the European Citizen's Initiative (ECI) is a tool aimed at increasing democratic participation of citizens in the European Union. Unlike petitions that are submitted to the European Parliament, the ECI allows EU citizens to propose legislations directly to the European Commission, given that they meet a certain numbers of conditions: the initiative must reach one million validated signatures from at least seven different member states within one year. In return, the Commission is obliged to examine the proposal and issue a formal response. In theory, the ECI aims to foster a more direct democracy in the EU through participatory digital infrastructure.

However, more than a decade after its debut, the ECI is still largely critiqued for its inefficiency. (Longo, 2019) Despite multiple initiatives launched, only five of them from 2012 to 2020 gathered enough signatures, and out of them only 2 led to tangible legislations. In 2021, an initiative that met all the conditions did not receive any further legal action. (Youngs, 2022) Indeed, while the Commission is obliged to examine the initiatives that have met the conditions, they are not forced to take any form of action. This lack of concrete action is often seen as undermining the core value of the ECI, which is to enhance participatory democracy in the EU. Therefore, critics were raised, arguing that the ECI functions more as a symbolic tool of legitimization for the EU than an actual tool for empowering EU citizens.

This paper argues that the lack of efficiency of the ECI does not solely come from the rigid rules and infrastructure of the EU institutions but is also embedded in the *socio-technical architecture of the initiative itself*. The ECI platform produces a specific mode of governance that constrains rather than enables political agency. Far from being a neutral technology, the website embodies a precise vision of citizenship: one that is individualised, datafied, and limited by strict procedures. The technocratic nature of the platform, added with the rigid legal constraints of the procedure, ultimately constraints the scope of participation. What appears as an opportunity for direct democracy initiatives actually works as an attribute of legitimacy for the EU, to face the criticism of its top-down management.

To support this argument, the paper proceeds in three parts. First, I will conduct a technical walkthrough of the ECI platform following the walkthrough method (Light, Burgess, & Duguay 2018), to trace the user experience when using the website. Then, I will analyse the underlying socio-technical governance model of the ECI, focusing on how its design and legal framework together shape a specific model of participation. Finally, I will offer policy recommendations that aims to reimagine the ECI as a more inclusive and dynamic tool to increase participation.

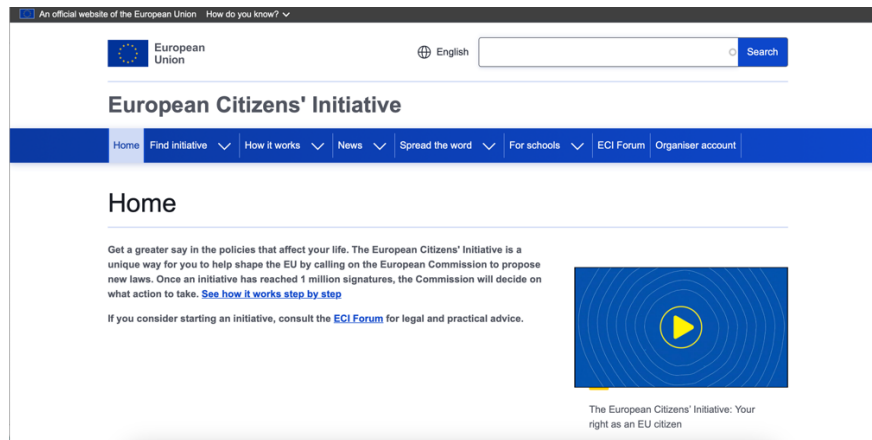
Walkthrough

The first part consists of a walkthrough of the European Citizens' Initiative website, following the methodological framework initially made for apps developed by Light, Burgess, and Duguay (2018). This approach is a way of engaging directly with the platform, to examine its mechanisms and underlying ideologies to understand how it guides users and shapes their experiences. The walkthrough was performed on 18/04/2025, using the Safari browser on a desktop computer.

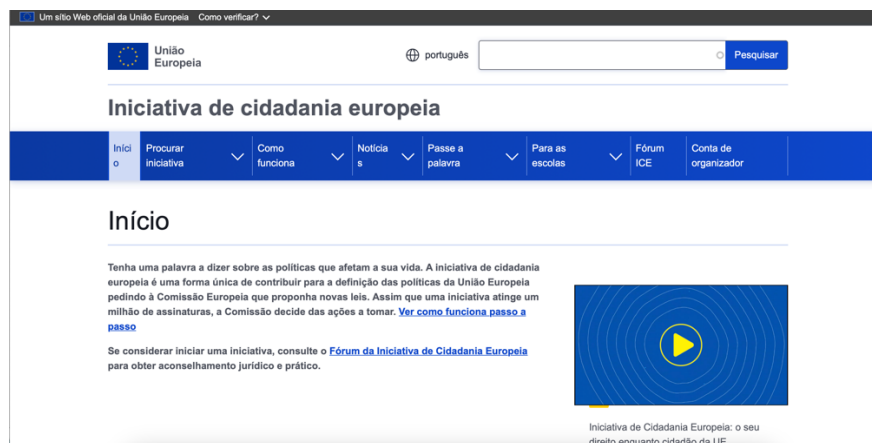
First impressions

First and foremost, a browser and a stable internet connexion are needed to arrive on the website (<https://citizens-initiative.europa.eu/en>). Once the language is chosen and cookies are accepted, the user finally gains access to its main page. (Figure 1) It is important to note that the website seems to have been

originally designed for English speakers, as putting the website in any other language will break the layout. (Figure 2)



(Figure 1: Main page of the ECI website)



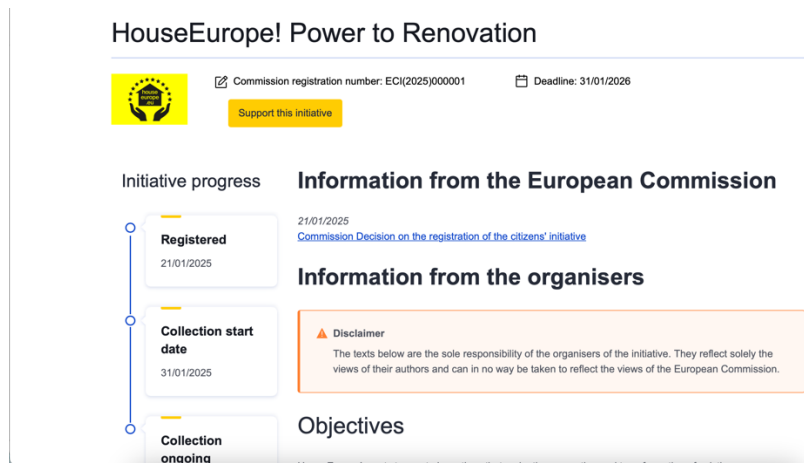
(Figure 2: Main page of the ECI website in Portuguese)

Once inside, the page is overwhelming in its textual density. The content is presented in long segmented blocks of small text, which raises concerns about the accessibility options of the website. Everything is written in a very formal, technical and very bureaucratic language. The minimalist design, used to embody the seriousness and visual identity of the EU with its white and blue colours, feels cold and distant. There is no guided user flow, but instead, a short one-minute video imported from YouTube to explain the concept of the ECI. A step-by-step tutorial is linked by clicking on the “See how it works step by step”, that explains how to *launch* an initiative. In the same way, the second link brings users wishing to *launch* an initiative to the ECI forum, a second website with even more technical text. (<https://citizens-initiative-forum.europa.eu/en>) The priority on the first page is given to citizens wanting to *launch* initiatives rather than citizens looking to inform themselves or support one. It is also important to note that a black EU-wide banner is constantly on the top of the page, signalling that it is an official government page, intended to promote trust and security.

Exploring an initiative

Scrolling down the main page of the website brings the user to all the currently active citizens' initiatives. They are sorted only by date of registration, with no filters for the topic, or popularity. With only 11 of them that are currently active, it is still quite easy to find all of them, but it does indicate that the website was coded for a small number of them being launched. Out of more than 448 million inhabitants in the EU as of 2024 according to the European Commission website, 11 seem like a very small number.

When clicking on one proposition, the page shows immediately its name as well as a countdown timer (for the 12 months limit), a red legal disclaimer and a prominent yellow "support" button. (Figure 3) The legal disclaimer warns users that the description of the content is at the responsibility of the citizens at the origin of the proposition, while the EU absolves itself from all responsibility to put it on citizens instead. Scrolling through the page allows the user to read a few paragraphs about the initiative and its legal scope. To get more information than that, a full legal proposal document is downloadable, but quite difficult to understand for most citizens because of its legal lexicon used. Overall, it seems like the citizen is positioned less as a political actor than as an administrative one filling out legal paperwork.



(Figure 3: Page of an initiative)

Signing an initiative

The protocol to sign an initiative is the following: after clicking on the "Support this initiative button", the citizen is taken to a new page of the website. This page summarises the objectives of the given proposal, a map of the EU with countries that have reached the threshold or not, an anonymous table of recent signatories, and finally a yellow banner to support it. (Figure 4) To go any further, it is necessary to indicate the country of the user's nationality. Indeed, depending on the country, the steps needed to support the initiative are different. Out of 27 EU countries, 19 of them have the opportunity to sign up with their government eID, or to fill in the form. The 8 other countries have no other choice than to fill up the form. Filling it is also different depending on the country of nationality. The user experience is not only dependent on the initiative being supported, but also on their national legal framework, over which they have no control. When filling in the form, for 18 countries, the following information are required: a number of identification (passport or identity card number), full first names, family names, a CAPTCHA verification as well as approving the following statement : *"I hereby certify that the information that I have provided in this form is correct and that I have not already supported this initiative."* For the 9 remaining countries, no personal identification number is needed but instead an address (with street, number, postal code, city, country) and date of birth, as well as one more statement to agree to: *"I have read the Privacy statement and the content of this citizens' initiative."* The requirement for an additional statement of agreement for some countries

reminds of the burden of responsibility that is put on the citizen — very few people will actually go read the 3500 words privacy statement available on the website, which name also sounds incredibly appealing: “Privacy policy concerning signatories’ personal data collected using the central online collection system”. Most users will not go through it and stop at the statement “Your personal data are duly protected.”. To get a user’s data removed, sending an email is necessary, and it does not guarantee its erasure. This pushes the narrative further of datafied citizenship: political engagement becomes a matter of form-filling, declaration, and verification, rather than deliberation, learning, understanding and mobilisation.

The screenshot shows the 'EUROPEAN CITIZENS' INITIATIVE - Central online collection system' interface. At the top, there's a navigation bar with the European Union logo and a language selector set to 'EN'. Below this, the title 'EUROPEAN CITIZENS' INITIATIVE - Central online collection system' is displayed. A prominent red banner reads 'HouseEurope! Power to Renovation'. The main content area features the European flag logo and the text 'European Citizens' Initiative'. To the right, a yellow box prompts users to 'Support this initiative proposed by European Union citizens' with a dropdown menu to 'Select your country of nationality'. Below the logo, the 'Objectives' section explains that HouseEurope! aims to create incentives for renovating existing buildings, boost the renovation market, and preserve historical value. It lists three key pillars: (i) tax reductions for renovation works and reused materials, (ii) fair rules to assess potentials and risks of existing buildings, and (iii) new values for embedded CO2 in existing structures. At the bottom, it mentions the initiative's presence in the European Commission's register.

(Figure 4: Supporting an initiative)

After signing

After signing, users are offered the options to share the initiative on social media (either on Facebook, LinkedIn, or X), leave a feedback rating (which is pre-filled as “Very Good” by default), or enter an email address to receive updates. (Figure 5) Users are then redirected to the ECI Forum, a platform supposed to be designed for discussion and community-building. In practice, it is not much used, poorly integrated, and has no impact on the Commission’s evaluation. From this point on, the citizen is fully removed from the process, with no ability to track what happens to their contribution besides email updates that I have never received despite supporting initiatives quite regularly in the past years. No transparent feedback loop is provided either. It is completely opaque.

The screenshot shows the 'Thank You!' confirmation page. At the top, a blue banner with a thumbs-up icon says 'Thank You! Your statement of support has been submitted successfully'. Below this, the 'Signature identifier' is displayed as '8e6f0902-4268-4367-8b61-34194aa42b10' with the 'Date of signature' as '24-Apr-2025'. A button labeled 'Download signature identifier' is provided. To the right, a section titled 'Tell your friends' encourages sharing the initiative on Facebook, X (Twitter), or LinkedIn. Below this, a link to 'Return to the website of the citizens' initiative' is shown. On the left, a feedback section asks 'How was the experience of supporting this initiative?' with radio buttons for 'POOR', 'FAIR', 'GOOD', and 'VERY GOOD' (which is selected). A text box below asks for feedback to improve the site. At the bottom right, there's a section to 'Please leave us your email address if you would like to stay informed:' with a checkbox for 'About this citizens' initiative (privacy statement)'.

(Figure 5: After signing)

Analysis

The walkthrough analysis of the ECI website reveals a system that, while supposed to foster genuine democratic participation, is designed in ways that limit and structure that very participation. This is especially true given the digital nature of the platform in itself, which excludes many participants who lack stable internet access. This section will explore how the ECI functions not just as a digital tool for submitting proposals and for citizens to have more political weight in the EU, but as an individualised gatekeeping infrastructure that regulates citizens' initiatives, while seemingly giving more legitimacy to the EU.

1. Proceduralising participation

From the first page, the website constructs an environment that prioritises a bureaucracy atmosphere rather than citizen engagement. It has a minimalist aesthetic with the signature white and blue EU colours with a bit of grey to represent the institutions. The text is written in a very small font and uses a very legal and administrative lexicon. There are no guided user flow, no warm colours or lots of pictures like in the [change.org](https://www.change.org) website, but instead an overall atmosphere that feels cold and distant. As argued by Winner (1980), the interface is not a neutral vector of information: it is considered as an *artefact* that shapes what is considered as citizen engagement through its very architecture, and these design choices embeds broader concepts and ideologies. Indeed, according to him, technologies contain both an *internal* and *external* logic, shaped by the values and norms of the society in which they are in. Here, the internal logic of the ECI platform can be considered as website in itself, its design and code. This internal logic is reinforced by the external logic of the EU governance structures, where direct participation is fundamentally limited in its functioning, and is expected to be orderly and non-disruptive to the current power structures. Indeed, these design features are not just about functionality or aesthetics but also political decisions, materialised in code (Lessig, 1999) and design. (Winner, 1980) Not only through its functioning but also through its architecture, the ECI pushes users into this predefined administrative roles, privileging form over expression. And the architecture of the website does not just reflect this institutional mindset: it actively enforces it. Citizens are not invited to deliberate or challenge the process, but indeed to just fill up their information in checkboxes, or to leave small feedback after signing (that is, important point, defaulted to "very good"). The citizen's role is constructed through their power to engage with the democratic process, and instead of empowering citizens, the role of the citizen presented by the ECI is one that is compliant, individualised, and datafied. Indeed, this general opacity of the website is also extended to data governance. To sign a petition and get access to this participation opportunity, users must enter their names, identity number or address, approve statement and do the CAPTCHA verification check. Depending on the country of nationality, for some, government eID is enough, for others, full addresses and declarations are mandatory to give, representation of the duality between national and supranational laws. This also enforces the existing differences within the EU's digital infrastructure, which undermines the ideal of a common European political identity. But this overall mechanism for citizens to give away their personal information is fundamentally asymmetrical. It is reflected in the ECI's privacy policy, that is long, obscurely titled, and overall, hardly accessible. While the citizen has to give sensitive information to vote, there is very little transparency in return from the EU. Any request regarding a user's data has to be done through writing an email, an additional step that not many users will take. The act of participation becomes similar as the one of a bureaucratic data submission, similar to the one of communicative capitalism, in which expression is captured and neutralised by procedural absorption. (Dean, 2009)

Overall, the ECI interface does exist solely as a way to give citizen a way to participate directly: it regulates and contains participation. It acts as a filtering and gatekeeping mechanism in which its design, legal structure and administrative procedure all narrow the scope of what participation *could* be: a disruptive, collective, and significantly politically transformative action.

2. Participation without Community

While the ECI is presented as a mechanism to increase participation, it fails to create any form of political community. Beyond filling up checkboxes to sign a petition, citizens are left alone in the process. This vision of participation echoes the argument of the platformisation of public life: even public institutions are adopting a platform logic that structures human interactions around data flows and metrics rather than public engagement. (Dijck, Poell, and de Waal, 2018) Participation becomes individualised, where citizens interact with the interface instead of with other citizens. But true democratic participation cannot be reduced to isolated inputs. It implies not only the ability to express ideas, but also to confront them with others, revise them, and collectively construct society, and specifically more in the context of the European Union. (Habermas, 1998) A participatory democracy requires a *public sphere* in which citizens can deliberate freely and educate themselves through others. (Habermas, 1981) In that sense, the ECI in itself cannot be qualified as a public sphere. Instead, to interact with each other, citizens are offered the opportunity to visit the ECI Forum. However, once again, the ECI forum is not only very limited in options but also guided mainly for citizens wishing to start an initiative. The result is a superficial and constraint form of participation that simulates inclusion, even though the sole concept of the ECI is not even known to most European citizens, let alone them participating, knowing that the electoral turnout of the European elections (the most important ones) fluctuates between 42 and 50% since the past 20 years. (Verian, 2024) This lack of participation from the community highlights the absence of a polycentric governance model in the EU, in which multiple actors share decision-making authority.

In this sense, the ECI represents a broader recent phenomenon in western democracies: the delegation of political mediation to technical systems. By embedding control into the interface itself, the platform neutralises any disruptive action before it can even form. The ECI is not just to be understood as a digital extension of the EU governance logics: it is a political actor in itself, one that configures the limits of what political participation can or cannot be. To take Winner's argument: "[technologies] can embody specific forms of power and authority". (Winner, 1980, p.121) The ECI does not only facilitate participation: it is a technocratic mechanism that creates a structure of control that allows input, but never disruption.

3. The ECI as a legitimacy device

Beyond its underlying ideologies, the ECI plays another symbolic role in the governance of the EU. Indeed, through the last paragraphs, numerous critics by scholars and the failures of the many initiatives revealed its inefficiency as a participatory platform, but its existence serves further than a promise of citizen engagement: it functions as an attribute of institutional legitimacy. More than an actual tool for participation, it serves more as a tool for public reassurance for the EU, to counter the criticism of its top-down management. If we consider legitimacy as something that is perceived to be so (Price & Price, 2023, p.3316), then corporations or institutions just need to *appear* accountable. In order to do so, the EU does not have to build a structure that would foster genuine participatory governance but instead one that *looks* like it does. In this case, the ECI can be considered to be designed to cultivate "attributes of legitimacy" (Ibid., p.3318) that would cover the absence of actual transformations. From its bureaucratic structure, legal text and procedures, while being officially branded as a "citizens' initiative", the ECI contributes to the narrative of the EU as an institution that listens and involves European citizens. All of these features can be considered as elements to create an "aesthetic of governance" (Ibid., p.3320), in which the ECI uses the same language

and architecture of democratic participation (“initiatives”, “forum”, “signatures” ...) without having any material consequences typically associated with those processes. Indeed, the Commission is under no obligation to act, but only to examine the proposal, and most of them do not result in any tangible policy change.

Therefore, not only is the ECI useful to serve as an attribute of legitimacy for the EU, but it also channels participation through controlled inputs. In that sense, the ECI can be understood not as a failure for the EU, but as a functional attribute of the EU’s legitimacy apparatus (Foucault, 1997).

Policy Recommendations

The failure of the ECI is not merely due to its functioning but is also deeply embedded in the very architecture of the platform. Therefore, reforms must also be applied at its technological level. The following recommendations are not just about changing the procedure, but about rethinking the ECI as a digital infrastructure for EU governance: one that pushes for deliberation, creates communities, and enables concrete action.

1. More Accessibility

As the walkthrough revealed, the ECI platform is uneven in design and experience. It privileges desktop users, English speakers, those familiar with legal lexicon and processes, and already-politically-interested citizens, which excludes a significant part of the EU population. (Longo, 2019) To address these disparities, the interface should be redesigned with more accessibility. In this matter, here are the policy recommendations to face this problem:

- The implementation of **multilingual parity**, not just in terms of translation, but also in layout and interface flow across languages.
- More **accessibility options** (according to the Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG 2.1)), including adjustable font sizes, screen reader compatibility, visual contrast options, and also visual and audio summaries of the proposals with clear language to make content understandable to more citizens.
- The development of a better **mobile version** of the website, as for many users, smartphones are the primary (or only) means of accessing most digital services
- A smoother (optional) **step-by-step onboarding process** when users first arrive. Possibly through a walkthrough, interactive tutorial, or clearly structured “how to participate” guide to make the process more accessible to all users, particularly for the ones engaging with the platform for the first time.

Democratic participation should not be reserved for the digitally literate or legally fluent. These improvements would not represent just technical upgrades but political commitments to inclusion and accessibility, for the ECI to genuinely be a European public platform representing the European values of democracy.

2. A deliberative space

Currently, one of the main criticisms raised about the ECI platform is its lack of community. The act of supporting an initiative is reduced to an individualist and bureaucratic act. The logic of the citizen as an administrative user filling out paperwork instead of an active speaker and contributor to society must be reversed. To achieve this, here are the implementations needed:

- The creation of **interactive spaces** on each initiative’s page where citizens can comment, raise concerns, or even suggest improvements. The citizens are the origin of the initiative also have the possibility to answer to each transparently.

- This space would be **moderated** at the expense of the EU, following the guidelines on social media regulation by the EU Code of Conduct+ (2025).
 - Citizens would be able to make **revisions** of proposals based on other citizens inputs, making initiatives living documents rather than fixed submissions.
- The ability for citizens to connect around the proposals, with organising local actions over the EU or other related events. When clicking on a proposal, the related events would appear on the page, as well as the next Citizen Dialogue (CD) organised.

The ECI should be transformed into a dynamic deliberative platform, that fosters political education, dialogue, and allows mobilisation. These recommendations would enable it to get closer to a truly democratic infrastructure, that would allow people not only to support a cause, but to shape it, defend it, and build it with a community.

3. Transparency from the Commission

Finally, one of the most alienating features of the current ECI is its absence of follow-up. Once an initiative is signed, the citizen is completely removed from the process. There are no public updates, no direct communications or emails, and no visible consequences unless the Commission voluntarily takes action. To resolve this, the platform must build transparency and traceability mechanisms.

- The Commission should provide **public reasoning** in all EU languages when an initiative is rejected, following the ECI Campaign demands. (<https://citizens-initiative.eu/#>) This response would be sent by email to the citizens who inputted their email address or publicly on the Commission's website and social media.
- An (optional) **notification system** should inform supporters of the initiatives if/when updates occur, rather than expecting them to revisit the site manually every once in a while.
- A better **feedback-loop mechanism** through an optional survey, accessible for all EU citizens even without signing an initiative.

These changes would not solve the broader issue of the EU's opacity but would establish more trust between the citizens actions and the institutional response, making participation more reciprocal and turning it into a genuine conversation rather than a dead-end.

Conclusion

The European Citizen's Initiative, while being presented as a mechanism for more participatory democracy in the EU, reveals through its architecture a model of governance that constrains more than it empowers political action. Through a user interface designed for form-filling rather than expression, it controls and individualise participation, framing it instead as administrative compliance. Users are guided through bureaucratic steps, without any opportunity to deliberate or interact with each other, and even ways to challenge the process. At the same time, these constraints are not to be understood as side effects, but as centrals to how the ECI operates, by neutralising the impact of participation to produce an aesthetic of governance that allows the EU to appear open and responsive. It is not just simply a malfunctioning participatory tool, but a functional device of legitimacy for the EU. In this light, the policy recommendations proposed do not just aim to improve the ECI's usability, but to reshape it as a genuine democratic infrastructure for more polycentric governance. The platform should become more accessible, more dialogic, and more transparent, through more accessibility features, participatory options, and visible institutional responses. If the EU wants to reclaim the promise of the ECI as a truly democratic tool, it must treat *design* as a political question, and *infrastructure* as a site of governance.

However, this paper also recognises the limits of the scope of a technological re-design. Indeed, this alone would not be sufficient without addressing the deeper legal and procedural architecture of the ECI in itself. The current rules, from the conditions an initiative should meet to the absence of binding consequences for the Commission significantly restrict the transformative potential of any citizen-led initiative through the ECI. So, while this paper has primarily focused on the technology, it must be acknowledged that reimagining the ECI also requires fundamental changes in its rules, following the ECI campaign's reform proposals. It is only through a combined effort to re-design both the technology and the legal frameworks that the ECI can begin to truly embody its democratic aspirations.

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